Meanwhile, a rearrangement had taken place on the other side of the Bohemian border. Rupert, king of Germany, had died in 1410, after a frustrating and fruitless decade on the throne. The electors had quarreled over the next candidate until 1411, finally settling on Sigismund, king of Hungary (after the death of his wife the queen) and survivor of the 1396 Battle of Nicopolis, younger son of Emperor Charles IV and brother of Wenceslaus IV.

Sigismund had moved, steadily, into the center of international intrigues. He was now forty-three years old: "tall, with bright eyes, broad forehead, pleasantly rosy cheeks, and a long thick beard," says the fifteenth-century chronicler Aeneas Sylvius, who later became Pope Pius II. "He had a large mind and formed many plans, but was changeable . . . witty in conversation, given to wine and women, and thousands of love intrigues are laid to his charge. . . . He made more promises than he kept, and often deceived."[14]

Hoping to simultaneously recover Bohemia, corral Italy, and solve the embarrassment of the triple papacy, Sigismund used his new authority as king of Germany to propose an international church council. He needed only one pope to sign off on the idea, and John XXIII agreed; most likely, he expected that the council would depose his two papal rivals.

It took several years to organize the council, but it finally convened in the German town of Constance two days before All Saints' Day, 1414. Nearly four hundred high-ranking clergy were present: archbishops, abbots, priors, and priests. But they were outnumbered by university leaders, scholars, and ambassadors from the courts of Europe. The council had two major problems to address—the spread of Wycliffe's heresies and the scandal of the three popes—and both were as much academic and political puzzles as theological dilemmas.

Constance was crowded out—not just with council attendees but with hundreds of merchants, clowns, jugglers, conjurers, musicians, barbers, and prostitutes. There was more carousing than contemplation in the streets: "The Swabians say," Jan Hus remarked, "that it will take thirty years to purify Constance of all its sins." One local resident estimated that seventy thousand outsiders descended on the city during the Council's deliberations.[15]

The opening act of the Council was to summon Jan Hus to defend his beliefs. Hus himself seems to have gotten the impression that the Council disapproved of him only because its members did not understand exactly what he was saying. He was further reassured when Sigismund himself pledged a royal safe-conduct: if Hus came to Constance, he would be allowed to depart again in peace. "Under the safe conduct of your protection, [I will] appear at the Council, the Lord Most High being my defender," Hus wrote back to the king, accepting the promise. "I have taught nothing in secret, but only in